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The Rules of Writing Poetry

Sunday June 24, 2007Sunday June 24, 2007 · Stacey Shubitz

One of my students, Allandra, just e-mailed me this morning. (She's also a co-author of [DEAL WITH IT! Powerful Words from Smart, Young Women](#). I'm not sure what prompted her note to me, but she decided to send me a list of "rules" for writing poetry. I've never had a list before, so I wasn't sure what to make of this at first. But then I read farther and felt a strange falling feeling in my chest as well as a flutter of excitement in my heart. It's that end-of-the-year feeling that we get when we know we've taught something to our students and that they've internalized it. However, it's also that feeling of "Oh wow, they're leaving me now."

That being said, here are Allandra's Rules of Writing Poetry":

Rules of Writing Poetry

There is some confusion in poetry. Does it have to rhyme or make sense? No, not necessarily.

- 1. Poetry doesn't have to rhyme.**
- 2. Poetry doesn't have to make sense.**
- 3. It needs plenty of details.**
- 4. Keep an open mind as you write.**
- 5. As a suggestion create a list of topics that you know are already on your mind at the moment.**
- 6. Add your true feelings and ideas to whatever you decide to write about.**

Examples:

Bad Example of an Acrostic Poem:

Holding
Apple
Poodle
Price
You

Good Example of an Acrostic Poem:

Happy feelings all around
A look of joy upon faces
Purposely smiling
People get the inspiration to smile
You should too!

- 7. Always remember to put tons of feeling into it and make sure you keep the memories in mind because it can always help you create a really good poem.**
- 8. Have help from a friend or family member (as a peer editor).**
- 9. Think before you begin writing poetry.**
- 10. Take a moment write a list and check off the topics along the way.**

Don't you love when kids surprise you and amaze you. I can think of no better end-of-the-year gift than the one Allandra e-mailed to me this morning.

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Stacey Shubitz is a K-6 literacy consultant and former elementary teacher. She is the author of CRAFT MOVES and other professional books on writing workshop. Her new book, MAKE THE SCHOOL SYSTEM WORK FOR YOUR CHILD WITH DISABILITIES (Guilford Press, 2026), empowers parents to navigate the special education system. [View all posts by Stacey Shubitz](#)

2 thoughts on “The Rules of Writing Poetry”

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2. *April Sampson*

says:

THURSDAY FEBRUARY 21, 2008 AT 9:35 AM

I was looking for rules of poetry as I was told that I did not have the same number of syllables in each stanza. Is this really important as I have been checking over some poetry that I used to read as a child and it did not have the same syllables in each stanza.

So if you could let me know what the rules are exactly are I would appreciate it . Thanks so much
April

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